

Apply for a Science Corps Fellowship - Entry #882

Name
Swastika Issar
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Gender
Female
City, state, and country of residence
Radolfzell am Bodensee, Baden-Württemberg, Germany
Nationality
Indian
When did or will you finish your PhD?
29 January 2022
University Education
1. PhD Zoology University of Cambridge, Cambridge, United Kingdom 29 January 2022 2. MSc Environmental Studies TERI University, New Delhi, India 5 January 2014 3. BSc Biological Sciences University of Delhi, New Delhi, India 24 March 2012
What are your reasons for applying to be a Science Corps fellow?
As a first-generation academic, navigating the scholastic landscape has been an uncharted adventure for me. Throughout this journey, I've had the pleasure of working with incredibly talented researchers across many scientific disciplines, from diverse educational and cultural backgrounds. Having personally flourished in such environments that promoted the exploration of new ideas, I firmly believe that a diverse and interdisciplinary community of researchers lays a strong foundation for innovation and scientific progress. Teaching and developing a research methods and biology curriculum as part of Science Corps' mission of empowering students to pursue degrees in STEM fields, would be an exciting next step for my growth as an academic and as a diversity advocate at the forefront of cultural changes towards greater inclusion in STEM fields. Through developing a hands-on research project with the students and tapping into our cross-cultural sense of collective curiosity, I want to better contextualise the scientific questions that drive me as I prepare to lead my own research group in the future. Above all, the ethos of Science Corps strongly echoes my own view that science is and should be for everyone.
In addition to your studies, describe any relevant experiences that have prepared you for a Science Corps fellowship.

While serving as president of my undergraduate Social Service Society, a chance encounter led me to establish a literacy program focussed on low-income migrant worker communities in South Delhi. Later, while working on genotypic and phenotypic diversity in flour beetle populations at the National Centre for Biological Sciences, I mentored undergraduate and graduate students in lab skills, insect handling and experimental design. During my PhD, I trained in pedagogical techniques through the Researcher Development Programme and used this training as assistant supervisor of undergraduate practicals in animal physiology, behaviour, and evolution. I really enjoyed my stint as Biology Teaching Assistant to high school students at Long Road Sixth Form College through STIMULUS, a community programme which gives university students the opportunity to work with pupils in local schools. Giving seminars and talks on burying beetle ecology to broad audiences has helped me hone my skills in turning complex findings into concise and simple concepts. I've had the privilege of working with talented young students as a STEM mentor at The Bhagini Project, a women's collective that connects Indian women to mentors in their field of interest. These experiences taught me that teaching and mentoring responsibilities often go hand in hand.

Where do you imagine yourself professionally in the future? Check all that apply.

Academic scientist in academia

In science education

In science outreach

Other

Expand on your selection above and describe where you imagine yourself professionally in the near (two year) and long-term (ten year) future.

What excites me most about a career in scientific research is the opportunity to probe the very fundamentals of how life evolves and continues to diversify on our planet. My long-term goal is to lead my own lab as a Principal Investigator. Therefore, my postdoctoral research and teaching experience in the near future will set the stage for my career as an independent researcher exploring how natural selection shapes interactions within social groups, species and ecological communities. A key goal during my postdoctoral work would be to develop skills that enable me to nurture a culture of creativity, innovation, and collegiality in my lab and to proactively work towards greater equity, diversity, and inclusion in academia. Along with my extensive experience in teaching and mentoring since my undergraduate studies, I am deeply passionate about science education. Through outreach projects, I want to tell stories that inspire, fascinate, and raise awareness about the natural world. A Science Corps fellowship would be an empowering experience for me that will pave the path towards a successful future in research and academia by facilitating independent exploration, personal growth, and learning.

CV/Resume

 [CV-S.-Issar.pdf](#)

How did you find out about Science Corps?

EvoDir

Any other comments/questions?

Empty

[Science Corps](#)